told me about the humiliation he felt when he had no money left to give his wife. There was nothing I could say, so I stopped walking and hugged him.

This happened again and again. It happened with children, with mothers and with students. It happened with shopkeepers, carpenters and labourers. It happened with soldiers. Now I would almost never hear myself or the crowd. My attention would not move from the person who spoke in my ear. The constant chatter and judgement inside me were gone. When a student would say they were scared of failing, I would listen. When a group of little children who were forced on to the streets to beg for a living shivered in front of me one morning, I decided I would walk in my T-shirt until I no longer could. The object of my love had suddenly revealed herself. My beloved Bharat Mata was not a land. It wasn't a set of ideas. It wasn't a particular culture, history or religion. Neither was it the caste that people had been assigned. India was the voice of every single Indian, no matter how weak or strong. India was the happiness, the fear and the pain hidden deep inside all the voices.

To hear India, my own voice, my desires and my ambitions had to fall silent. India would speak to one of her own, but only if one was humble and completely silent.

How simple it had turned out to be. I had been looking in the river for that which could only be found in the sea.

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1 Rahul Gandhi, '*Bharat Mata: The Voice of Every Indian*', Indian National Congress, 15 October 2023, https://inc.in/in-focus/bharat-mata-the-voice-of-every-indian (last accessed on 20 February 2024).